scraps, the pollen of Typha latifolia, the catkins of the willow, cotton, reed, Tecoma grandiflora, soft leaves, dry moths, the ear-shells, hemp or beans'.[4] The monks store books and utensils in niches cut into the thick walls. All this reminds me of my own spartan hostel room at IIT Kharagpur, which too had just enough room for a narrow cot, a desk and a chair, and a cupboard with stone slabs for shelves.

I walk up to the Great Monument, which is still decorated with a few fine sculptural panels of stucco or stone. It has multiple stairs going to the top. In Yijing's time, it had a 'hall with mosaic floor', a seat 'made of gold and studded with jewels' and 'an image of the Buddha Tathagata' turning the Wheel of Law.[5] I try to imagine 'the ornamentation of the [Great Monument that] was delicate and superb', according to Yijing. At its base may have been the famous library of Nalanda, though a Tibetan source speaks of a library with nine storeys, which seems implausible for the building technology of the day. In any case, the library's location remains uncertain. It held the sorts of manuscripts that the Chinese pilgrims came in search of (at least eight finely illustrated palm-leaf manuscripts created at Nalanda during the Pala period still survive).

Nalanda was a place for advanced learning, not basic education. Some of its teachers both taught *and* composed path-breaking treatises and commentaries. A Nalanda education held serious cachet in the scholastic community, and it took in the best and the brightest. Or as Xuanzang puts it, they were 'men of the highest ability and talent . . .there are many hundreds whose fame has rapidly spread through distant regions'. Aspiring students had to be at least twenty years old and pass an oral exam at the monastery's entrance. They had to 'show their ability by hard discussion' and demonstrate a deep knowledge of 'both old and new books before getting admission'. No more than two or three out of ten were admitted, and even they were promptly humbled by the calibre of their teachers and co-students. Nuns were admitted too but little record of their lives survives.

Xuanzang wrote that during his time, Nalanda's population was 10,000, including 8500 students and 1500 teachers in 108 residential monasteries, each with four floors. Many scholars consider these numbers too high. Did Xuanzang exaggerate them for his Chinese audience to increase Nalanda's prestige and, indirectly, his own? A generation later, Yijing estimated